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Civilization: Moral and Ethical Foundation (RICC Khutbah)

الحمد لله نحمده ونستعينه ونستغفره، ونعوذ بالله تعالى من شرور أنفسنا، وسيئات أعمالنا، ، وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له، وأشهد أن محمداً عبده ورسوله، اللهم صل وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن تبعه إلى يوم الدين

Last week, we began this series of talks on **The Qur'an: A Blueprint for Civilization and Salvation**. We saw that the civilization the Qur'an seeks to establish rests upon seven interdependent pillars:

1. Moral and ethical foundation
2. Governance and justice
3. Knowledge and education
4. Economic prosperity
5. Science and technology
6. Defense and security
7. Cultural and artistic flourishing

Today, in sha' Allah, we begin with the first pillar: the moral and ethical foundation. The Qur'an places extraordinary emphasis on character, ethics, and values because they are the foundation upon which every successful civilization is built. Laws alone cannot produce justice. Wealth alone cannot produce prosperity. Power alone cannot preserve a nation.

A just government cannot function without just people. A prosperous economy cannot survive without honesty. Strong institutions cannot endure without trustworthy leaders. Morality without institutions becomes powerless, but institutions without morality become oppressive.

For this reason, every pillar that follows in this series ultimately rests upon this first pillar. The Qur'an develops this moral foundation through many commands. Today I will highlight nine of them, mentioning one verse for each.

1. Justice and Fairness

Justice is among the greatest commands in the Qur'an. Its standard is absolute. Allah commands justice even when it is against ourselves, our parents, or our closest relatives.

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا كُونُوا قَوَّامِينَ بِالْقِسْطِ شُهَدَاءَ لِلَّهِ وَلَوْ عَلَىٰ أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَوِ الْوَالِدِينَ وَالْأَقْرَبِينَ إِن يَكُنْ غَنِيًّا أَوْ فَقِيرًا فَاللَّهُ أَوْلَىٰ بِهِمَا فَلَا تَتَّبِعُوا الْهَوَىٰ أَنْ تَعْدِلُوا وَإِنْ تَلَوْا أَوْ تَعْرَضُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كَانَ بِمَا تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيرًا (١٣٥)

“O you who have believed, be upholders of justice, witnesses for Allah, even if it be against yourselves or parents and relatives. Whether one is rich or poor, Allah is better caretaker of both. So, do not follow [personal] inclination, lest you not be just. And if you distort [your testimony] or refuse [to give it], then indeed Allah is all-aware of what you do.” (Al-Nisa 4: 135)

Justice is not determined by emotions, relationships, politics, or personal interest. It is a clear command from Allah.

2. Excellence in Conduct (Ihsan)

Justice sets the minimum standard. A civilization built only on minimum standards may survive. The Qur'an calls us to something even higher: Ihsan, doing more than what is merely required, a civilization built on Ihsan excels.

وَأَحْسِنُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (١٩٥)

and do good; indeed, Allah loves the doers of good." (Al-Baqarah 2: 195)

This standard of excellence extends beyond individual behavior to the collective identity of the Muslim community. The Qur'an defines the best of all communities not by race, wealth, or power, but by their moral commitment to what is right:

كُنْتُمْ خَيْرَ أُمَّةٍ أُخْرِجَتْ لِلنَّاسِ تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ

You are the best community that has been raised for mankind, you enjoin the right conduct (moral and fair conduct) and forbid the unfair and indecency and you believe in Allah. (Al-E-Imran 3:110)

Without a strong moral foundation, no civilization can be truly "best" regardless of its material achievements. The Qur'an makes clear that this title of distinction is earned through ethical conduct, not inherited by birth.

3. Truthfulness and Honesty

Trust is the foundation of every healthy family, business, and society. A society where deception is normalized cannot sustain trust in its institutions, contracts, or relationships. The Qur'an commands believers to align themselves with the truthful as a matter of identity:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَكُونُوا مَعَ الصَّادِقِينَ (١١٩)

"O you who have believed, fear Allah and be with those who are truthful." (Al-Tawba 9:119)

Truthfulness here is about avoiding lies, it is a call to surround oneself with people of integrity, to build a community whose culture is rooted in honesty.

4. Humility and Avoiding Arrogance

One of the greatest destroyers of civilizations is arrogance. It corrupts leadership, destroys relationships, and blinds people to truth. The Qur'an addresses it directly:

وَلَا تُصَغِّرْ حَدَّكَ لِلنَّاسِ وَلَا تَمْشِ فِي الْأَرْضِ مَرَحًا إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ كُلَّ مُخْتَالٍ فَخُورٍ (١٨)

"And do not turn your cheek in contempt toward people and do not walk through the earth arrogantly. Indeed, Allah does not like everyone self-deluded and boastful." (Luqman 31:18)

The physical imagery here is powerful: the turned cheek and the arrogant posture are outward signs of an inward disease. Qur'anic moral formation works at both levels, shaping the inner character while also guiding outward behavior.

5. Kindness to Family, and Society

Immediately after commanding the worship of Him alone, Allah commands kindness to parents and then expands that kindness outward to relatives, neighbors, orphans, the needy, travelers, and others:

وَأَعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ وَلَا تُشْرِكُوا بِهِ شَيْئًا ۚ وَبِالْوَالِدَيْنِ إِحْسَنًا وَبِذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَالْيَتَامَىٰ وَالْمَسْكِينِ وَالْجَارِ ذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَالْجَارِ الْجُنُبِ وَالصَّاحِبِ بِالْجَنبِ وَابْنِ السَّبِيلِ وَمَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمَانُكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ مَن كَانَ مُخْتَالًا فَخُورًا (٣٦)

"Worship Allah and associate nothing with Him, and to parents do good, and to relatives, orphans, the needy, the near neighbor, the farther neighbor, the companion at your side, the traveler, and those whom your right hands possess. Indeed, Allah does not like those who are self-deluding and boastful." (Al-Nisa 4:36)

Notice how the Qur'an builds society: it begins with the family and gradually extends compassion to the entire community.

6. Patience, Forgiveness, and Responding to Evil with Good

A civilization that has no capacity for forgiveness and patience will be consumed by cycles of conflict and retaliation. No society can survive if every offense leads to revenge. The Qur'an offers a transformative principle:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلَاةِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ (١٥٣)

"O you who have believed, seek help through patience and prayer. Indeed, Allah is with the patient." (Al-Baqarah 2:153)

And beyond mere patience, the Qur'an calls for something even more powerful: responding to hostility with goodness, which has the capacity to transform an enemy into a friend:

وَلَا تَسْتَوِ الْحَسَنَةُ وَلَا السَّيِّئَةُ ۚ ادْفَعْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ فَإِذَا الَّذِي بَيْنَكَ وَبَيْنَهُ عَدَاوَةٌ كَأَنَّهُ وَلِيٌّ حَمِيمٌ (٣٤)
"And not equal are the good deed and the bad. Repel [evil] by that which is better; thereupon the one whom between you and him is enmity [will become] as though he was a devoted friend." (Fussilat 41:34)

This is not naivety. It is a sophisticated moral strategy: meeting wrong with goodness has the power to dissolve enmity and rebuild human bonds.

7. Human Dignity and Equality

The Qur'an rejects racism, tribalism, and every form of superiority except one of God-consciousness. Allah says:

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ إِنَّا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ وَأُنْثَىٰ وَجَعَلْنَاكُمْ شُعُوبًا وَقَبَائِلَ لِتَعَارَفُوا إِنَّ أَكْرَمَكُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَتَقْوَاهُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ خَبِيرٌ (١٣)

“O mankind, indeed, We have created you from a male and a female and made you into races and tribes that you may know one another. Indeed, the most noble of you in the sight of Allah is the most conscious of Allah among you. Indeed, Allah is All-Knowing, All-Aware.” (Al-Hujurat 49:13)

Diversity of race, language, and culture was not intended to be a source of conflict. It is by divine design, intended to produce mutual understanding and enrichment. Social cohesion is further commanded through the image of a single, unbreakable rope:

وَأَعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا

“Hold firmly, all of you, to the rope of Allah and do not become divided.” (Al-Imran 3:103)

Unity built on shared moral and spiritual values is far stronger and more durable than unity built on ethnicity or political interest alone.

8. A Complete Moral Code: The Charter of Al-Isra

Among the most remarkable passages in the Qur'an is the sequence in Surah Al-Isra (verses 23 to 37), which reads as a comprehensive moral charter

وَقَضَىٰ رَبُّكَ أَلَّا تَعْبُدُوا إِلَّا إِيَّاهُ وَبِالْوَالِدَيْنِ إِحْسَانًا ۚ إِنَّمَا بَيْتُكَ عِنْدَكَ الْكِبَرُ أَحَدُهُمَا أَوْ كِلَاهُمَا فَلَا تَقُلْ لَهُمَا أَفٌّ وَلَا تَنْهَرُهُمَا وَقُلْ لَهُمَا قَوْلًا كَرِيمًا (٢٣) وَأَخْفِضْ لَهُمَا جَنَاحَ الذِّلِّ مِنَ الرَّحْمَةِ وَقُلْ رَبِّ ارْحَمْهُمَا كَمَا رَبَّيَانِي صَغِيرًا (٢٤) رَبُّكُمْ أَعْلَمُ بِمَا فِي نُفُوسِكُمْ إِن تَكُونُوا صَالِحِينَ فَإِنَّهُ كَانَ لِلْأَوَّابِينَ غَفُورًا (٢٥) وَعَاتِذَا ذَا الْقُرْبَىٰ حَقَّهُ وَالْمِسْكِينَ وَابْنَ السَّبِيلِ وَلَا تُبَذِّرْ تَبْذِيرًا (٢٦) إِنَّ الْمُبَذِّرِينَ كَانُوا إِخْوَانَ الشَّيَاطِينِ وَكَانَ الشَّيْطَانُ لِرَبِّهِ كَفُورًا (٢٧) وَإِذَا تَعَرَّضْتُمْ عَنْهُمْ ابْتِغَاءَ رَحْمَةٍ مِّن رَّبِّكَ تَرْجُوهَا فَقُلْ لَهُمْ قَوْلًا مَّيْسُورًا (٢٨) وَلَا تَجْعَلْ يَدَكَ مَغْلُولَةً إِلَىٰ عُنُقِكَ وَلَا تَبْسُطْهَا كُلَّ الْبَسْطِ فَتَقْعُدَ مَلُومًا مَّحْسُورًا (٢٩) إِنَّ رَبَّكَ يَبْسُطُ الرِّزْقَ لِمَن يَشَاءُ وَيَقْدِرُ إِنَّهُ كَانَ بِعِبَادِهِ خَبِيرًا بَصِيرًا (٣٠) وَلَا تَقْتُلُوا أَوْلَادَكُمْ حَسْبِيَ إِمْلَاقِي نَحْنُ نَرْزُقُهُمْ وَإِيَّاكُمْ إِن قَتَلْتُمْهُمْ كَانَتْ خَطَا كَبِيرًا (٣١) وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا الزَّوْجَ إِنَّهُ كَانَ فَجْشَةً وَسَاءَ سَبِيلًا (٣٢) وَلَا تَقْتُلُوا النَّفْسَ الَّتِي حَرَّمَ اللَّهُ إِلَّا بِالْحَقِّ ۚ وَمَن قَتَلَ مَظْلُومًا فَقَدْ جَعَلْنَا لَوْلِيَّهِ سُلْطَانًا فَلَا يَسْرِفُ فِي الْقَتْلِ إِنَّهُ كَانَ مَنْصُورًا (٣٣) وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا مَالَ الْيَتِيمِ إِلَّا بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ حَتَّىٰ يَبْلُغَ أَشُدَّهُ ۚ وَأَوْفُوا بِالْعَهْدِ ۚ إِنَّ الْعَهْدَ كَانَ مَسْئُولًا (٣٤) وَأَوْفُوا الْكَيْلَ إِذَا كِلْتُمْ وَزَنُوا بِالْقِسْطَاسِ الْمُسْتَقِيمِ ذَٰلِكَ خَيْرٌ وَأَحْسَنُ تَأْوِيلًا (٣٥) وَلَا تَقْفُ مَا لَيْسَ لَكَ بِهِ عِلْمٌ ۚ إِنَّ السَّمْعَ وَالْبَصَرَ وَالْفُؤَادَ كُلُّ أُولَٰئِكَ كَانَ عَنْهُ مَسْئُولًا (٣٦) وَلَا تَمْشِ فِي الْأَرْضِ مَرَحًا ۚ إِنَّكَ لَن تَخْرِقَ الْأَرْضَ وَلَن تَبْلُغَ الْجِبَالَ طُولًا (٣٧)

“And your Lord has decreed that you worship none but Him, and that you show kindness to parents..... And do not walk upon the earth exultantly. Indeed, you will never tear the earth apart, and you will never reach the mountains in height.” (Al-Isra 17:23-37)

These verses form one of the most comprehensive ethical charters ever revealed and provide the moral blueprint for both individuals and societies. Within only fifteen verses, Allah presents an extraordinary moral charter covering worship, kindness to parents, care for relatives and the poor, financial responsibility, protection of life, honesty in trade, fulfillment of promises, intellectual responsibility, and humility.

9. The Comprehensive Definition of Righteousness (Al-Birr)

The Qur'an does not leave the concept of righteousness vague or open to selective interpretation. In one of its most definitive moral statements, it provides a complete and structured definition:

لَيْسَ الْبِرَّ أَنْ تُوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ قِبَلَ الْمَشْرِقِ وَالْمَغْرِبِ وَلَكِنَّ الْبِرَّ مَنْ ءَامَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَالْمَلَائِكَةِ
وَالْكِتَابِ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ وَءَاتَى الْمَالَ عَلَى حُبِّهِ ذَوِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَالْيَتَامَىٰ وَالْمَسْكِينِ وَابْنَ السَّبِيلِ وَالسَّائِلِينَ وَفِي
الرِّقَابِ وَأَقَامَ الصَّلَاةَ وَءَاتَى الزَّكَاةَ وَالْمُوفُونَ بِعَهْدِهِمْ إِذَا عَاهَدُوا وَالصَّابِرِينَ فِي الْبَأْسَاءِ وَالضَّرَاءِ وَحِينَ
الْبَأْسِ أُولَئِكَ الَّذِينَ صَدَقُوا وَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْمُتَّقُونَ (١٧٧)

“Righteousness is not that you turn your faces toward the east or the west. But righteousness is in one who:

- 1. Believes in Allah, the Last Day, the Angels, the Book, and the Prophets.**
- 2. Gives wealth, despite loving it, to relatives, orphans, the needy, the traveler, those who ask, and for the freeing of those in bondage.**
- 3. Establishes prayer and gives regular charity.**
- 4. Fulfills covenants when they are made.**
- 5. Is patient in times of hardship, adversity, and during moments of crisis.**

Such are the people of truth, and such are the God-conscious.” (Al-Baqarah 2:177)

This remarkable verse teaches us that righteousness is not merely rituals or outward appearances. It combines five essential dimensions:

- Correct belief.
- Generosity toward others.
- Worship of Allah.
- Honesty in fulfilling commitments.
- Patience during hardship.

Together, these five dimensions give a portrait of the complete believer, and the foundation of a healthy civilization. A society that embodies all five is one that can genuinely claim the title of the "best nation" invoked in Al-Imran 3:110.

كُنْتُمْ خَيْرَ أُمَّةٍ أُخْرِجَتْ لِلنَّاسِ تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ

You are the best community that has been raised for mankind, you enjoin the right conduct (moral and fair conduct) and forbid the unfair and indecency and you believe in Allah. (Al-E-Imran 3:110)

Conclusion: Morality as the Root of Civilization

Whenever historians study the rise and fall of civilizations, they often focus on armies, economies, technology, or political power. The Qur'an begins somewhere else.

- It begins with the human heart.
- Before building governments, it builds character.
- Before reforming institutions, it reforms individuals.
- Before changing the world, it changes the soul.

That is why the first pillar of Qur'anic civilization is not wealth, science, or military strength.

- It is moral character.
- If this foundation is strong, the remaining pillars can stand.
- If this foundation collapses, no amount of wealth, power, or technology can save a civilization.

"Next week, in sha' Allah, we will see that good character by itself is not enough. The Qur'an therefore builds the second pillar of civilization: **governance and justice**. Morality without institutions becomes powerless, while institutions without morality become oppressive."

Because we still have few minutes, let me introduce one element of the second pillar on governance.

Governance is the mechanism through which a society organizes itself, administers justice, allocates resources, resolves disputes, and upholds its value. The Qur'an does not leave governance to political theory alone. **It establishes six foundational principles of righteous governance.** These principles go beyond simply having a leader. They describe a robust, adaptable, and equitable system grounded in divine command.

1. Governance is a Trust Built on Justice

The Qur'an summarizes the entire philosophy of governance in one remarkable verse that combines two inseparable duties: the faithful discharge of trust and the delivery of justice. These two duties define what legitimate authority means:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُكُمْ أَنْ تُؤَدُّوا الْأَمَانَاتِ إِلَىٰ أَهْلِهَا وَإِذَا حَكَمْتُمْ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ أَنْ تَحْكُمُوا بِالْعَدْلِ

"Indeed, Allah commands you to deliver trusts to those entitled to them, and when you judge between people, judge with justice." (An-Nisa 4:58)

This verse establishes two inseparable principles:

First principle is Amanah (Trustworthiness): Positions of authority are trusts, not entitlements. A ruler, judge, administrator, or public official holds their role on behalf of the people and before Allah. They are obligated to discharge it faithfully, placing it in the hands of those most qualified to carry it.

Trustworthiness alone is not sufficient. The Qur'anic concept of Amanah also requires competence. A position should be entrusted to those capable of fulfilling its responsibilities. Good intentions cannot compensate for the absence of ability.

This principle is illustrated by Prophet Yusuf (AS) who did not appeal merely to his righteousness, he appealed to both his integrity and his competence:

أَجْعَلْنِي عَلَى خَزَائِنِ الْأَرْضِ إِنِّي حَفِيظٌ عَلَيْهَا

Appoint me over the storehouses of the land. Indeed, I am a trustworthy guardian and knowledgeable.” (Yusuf 12:55)

The two qualities are inseparable, Hafeez (trustworthy and reliable) and Aleem (knowledgeable and competent). Sound governance therefore requires both integrity and competence. When either is absent, the public trust is endangered.

Second principle in the Ayat is Adl (Justice): Allah commands: "...and when you judge between people, judge with justice."

Justice is not influenced by family, politics, wealth, or personal preference. It is obedience to Allah.

Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) is himself commanded to embody this standard:

وَأْمُرْتُ لِأَعْدِلَ بَيْنَكُمُ اللَّهُ رَبُّنَا وَرَبُّكُمْ

“I am commanded to judge justly between you. Allah is our Lord and your Lord.” (Ash-Shura 42:15)

Justice in governance is not a concession to political circumstance. It is a divine command binding on the highest authority in the land.

The Qur'an further expands this command into a comprehensive moral and civic framework:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَالْإِحْسَانِ وَإِيتَايَ ذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَيَنْهَىٰ عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ وَالْبَغْيِ يَعِظُكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَذَكَّرُونَ

“Indeed, Allah commands justice, excellence in conduct, and giving to relatives, and forbids immorality, bad conduct, and oppression. He admonishes you that perhaps you will be reminded.” (An-Nahl 16:90)

For governance specifically, the prohibition of oppression (al-baghy) is of particular significance. Oppression by those in power, whether through exploiting public resources, silencing dissent, denying rights, or applying law selectively, is explicitly forbidden. A government that practices oppression has violated the most basic condition of its legitimacy in the Qur'anic framework.

Next week, we will inshallah continue with discussion on the five additional principles of righteous governance.

May Allah make us among those who embody the morals of the Qur'an, establish justice, excel in goodness, speak the truth, show humility, honor every human being, fulfill our trusts, and become a source of righteousness for our families, our communities, and our Ummah.

DUA